

# THE AILING PLANET: THE GREEN MOVEMENT'S ROLE

By Nani Palkhivala

## Summary (Briefly):

This essay by Nani Palkhivala discusses the deteriorating condition of our planet due to human greed and misuse of natural resources. It highlights the Green Movement launched in 1972, which made people realize that the Earth's resources are not unlimited and must be used responsibly. The author emphasizes the need for sustainable development, population control, and responsible governance to protect the environment for future generations.

1. Locate the lines in the text that support the title 'The Ailing Planet'.

Answer: The lines that support the title are:

"The earth's vital signs reveal a patient in declining health."

"Are we to leave our successors a scorched planet of advancing deserts, impoverished landscapes, and ailing environment?"

These lines show that the Earth is sick due to human exploitation and neglect.

2. What does the notice "The world's most dangerous

animal" at a zoo at Lusaka, Zambia, signify?

Answer: The notice points to a mirror inside the cage, showing a reflection of the visitor. It signifies that human beings themselves are the most dangerous species on Earth because they are destroying nature and endangering all life forms.

3. How are the Earth's principal biological systems being depleted?

Answer: The Earth's four principal biological systems — fisheries, forests, grasslands, and croplands — are being overused and damaged by human activity.

Fisheries are collapsing due to overfishing.

Forests are disappearing because of deforestation.

Grasslands are turning into deserts due to overgrazing.

Croplands are losing fertility because of excessive use and soil erosion.

This overexploitation threatens the survival of all living beings.

4. Why is the growth of the world population described as "the biggest threat to the future of human existence"?

Answer: Population growth increases the demand for food, water, housing, and resources, leading to overuse of land, deforestation, pollution, and unemployment. The more people there are, the more pressure we put on nature — making it

the greatest threat to humanity's survival.

5. In what way is the author's tone "urgent and serious"?

Answer: The author's tone is urgent and serious because he wants to warn humanity about the critical condition of the Earth. He emphasizes that immediate action is needed to save our planet from environmental collapse and to ensure a sustainable future.

6. "We have not inherited this earth from our forefathers; we have borrowed it from our children." Discuss.

Answer: This means that we are only temporary custodians of the planet. The Earth belongs to future generations as much as it does to us. Therefore, we have a moral responsibility to use its resources wisely so that our children inherit a healthy, livable planet — not a damaged one.

7. The problems of overpopulation directly affect our natural resources and environment. Discuss.

Answer: Overpopulation leads to overuse of forests, water, and land, resulting in deforestation, pollution, and loss of biodiversity. More people mean more demand for food, housing, and energy, which causes ecological imbalance. Hence, population control is essential to protect our environment.

8. Why does the author call the Earth “an ailing planet”?

Answer: The author calls the Earth “ailing” because its resources and ecosystems are declining rapidly due to human exploitation. Pollution, deforestation, overpopulation, and loss of species have weakened the Earth — like a sick patient in need of urgent care.

### III. Thinking about Language

1. Locate examples of the use of the following prepositions in the text.

(to, of, for, on, in)

Examples:

“According to the World Bank...”

“The population of the world is increasing.”

“We have a responsibility for our planet.”

“The Green Movement was born on 5 June 1972.”

“The Earth’s resources are limited in quantity.”

### IV. Extra Important Questions

1. What is the Green Movement?

Answer: The Green Movement started in 1972 to raise

awareness about environmental protection and sustainable development. It marked a global shift in thinking — from seeing Earth as a resource to recognizing it as a living system that needs care.

2. What is the concept of sustainable development?

Answer: Sustainable development means using natural resources wisely so that the needs of the present are met without compromising the ability of future generations to meet their own needs.

3. How does Nani Palkhivala describe the new world vision?

Answer: He describes it as a vision where the world sees the Earth as a living organism with limited resources that must be protected through responsibility, cooperation, and respect for nature.

4. What does the author suggest to protect the planet?

Answer: The author suggests:

Population control

Conservation of natural resources

Afforestation and protection of forests

Sustainable economic growth

Environmental education and awareness

5. What is the central idea of the essay?

*Answer: The central idea is that the Earth is sick because of human actions. To save it, we must act responsibly, control population, conserve resources, and adopt sustainable development. The essay is a call for global environmental awareness and action.*

✓ *Moral / Message of the Essay:*

*We must act as trustees of the planet, not exploiters.*

*The Earth's survival depends on our awareness, compassion, and sense of responsibility toward nature.*

